

Fact Brief: Has San Jose been using Automated License Plate Reader cameras for at least 15 years?



by [Donovan Farnham](#) June 17, 2026



An automated license plate reader from Flock Safety. Photo courtesy of the Santa Clara County Sheriff's Office.

No.

Fact Brief



San Jose has not been using automated license plate reader (ALPR) cameras for 15 years.

According to San Jose Police Department records, the first ALPR camera went up in May 2022 during the pilot program. That December the SJPd led another pilot program with the controversial cameras in seven more neighborhoods impacted by violent crime.

In the 2022-23 budget year, the SJPd expanded its use of the cameras to seven intersections near areas of high retail theft, such as Westgate Valley Fair, Westgate Center, Evergreen and Blossom Hill.

Fast forward to 2026, the SJPd now operates 474 ALPR cameras around the city through its vendor contract with Flock. The deployment has ruffled privacy concerns among residents. A group of San Jose citizens filed a class action lawsuit against the city alleging the surveillance cameras violated the Fourth Amendment which protects against unreasonable searches and seizures.

This fact brief is responsive to conversations such as [this one](#).

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Sources

San Jose Police Department [SJPd Expands ALPR Program Targeting Organized Retail Theft](#)

San Jose Police Department [Automated License Plate Reader Policy](#)

Institute for Justice [Three San Jose Residents File Federal Class Action Lawsuit Over City's Mass Surveillance of Drivers](#)